

FOR PRADEEP AGGARWAL, Founder-Chairman of Signature Global (India), good corporate governance is not just about complying with rules and stating the said compliance in officialese in the annual report. Aggarwal is a stickler for corporate governance as he knows it defines success in any field—including the fields of the then Gurgaon's Sector 107 in 2014.

That was where (and when) Aggarwal, after two decades in the stock markets, put together a crack team to enter the real estate business as the government pushed the concept of affordable housing.

Aggarwal announced his first housing project in 2014, and investors and buyers lapped it up. The project was oversubscribed three times. The prices clicked (up to ₹25 lakh for 1BHK and 2BHK apartments, unbelievably affordable even then). The delivery schedule clicked (announced in 2014 and delivered in 2018). Construction quality clicked.

Solera, Signature Global's first housing project, was born. Even today, the complex of six G+14 towers flanked by a G+3 row is a star draw in Gurugram (Gurgaon's new name since 2016).

Around Solera, dozens of real estate firms in Delhi-NCR, of which Haryana's Gurugram district is a part, went bust because of poor governance, leaving homebuyers high and dry. Some, like Amrapali Developers, got into unrelated businesses, diverted funds, and were accused of bouncing cheques. The Supreme Court bailed out some homebuyers. Parliament deployed the Real Estate Regulatory Authority, or RERA, in 2016. Unscathed by the crisis, Signature Global is one of the leading players today (*see graphic 'The Big Boys' Club'*). Aggarwal ensures that the company's projects align with the stringent RERA.

For Aggarwal, who started his career in 1986 as a 17-year-old in his father's agri-commodities business in old Delhi's Naya Bazar, becoming a realtor was not an obvious choice. After the Harshad Mehta scam of 1992 left the market in tatters, he saw an opportunity in arbitrage operations. "I started in 1993 and was primarily into arbitrage, which is considered a 'risk-free' business," he says.

Today, at 55, dressed in his navy blue suit, Aggarwal is the picture of a go-getter in his corner room at Signature Global's headquarters in Gurugram as we talk about his plans and how, in 2013, Aggarwal and his brothers (Lalit, Devender and Ravi) got into real estate. The trigger was the Haryana government's policy to encourage private developers in the



"Thriving in this evolving [Indian real estate] market requires a deep understanding of fluctuating costs"

SUMIT RAKSHIT
MANAGING DIRECTOR,
PROJECT MANAGEMENT
SERVICES, SAVILLS INDIA



"In a market where few developers have survived, they (Signature Global) have done well given the focus on governance and financial discipline"

ANUJ PURI
CHAIRMAN, ANAROCK GROUP

affordable housing market. "Being in the stock market, we have had this habit of extensively researching companies and sectors. We did door-to-door surveys in corporate offices and realised a high demand for homes priced at ₹25-30 lakh. But very few such apartments were coming up in Gurugram," he says.

Although the Aggarwals had zero experience in the real estate sector, their expertise in management, finance, marketing, and team building proved useful. "But most importantly, we focussed on corporate governance," he says.

Experts concur. Signature Global has flourished because of its stringent practices, says Anuj Puri, Chairman of Anarock Group, which is into real estate services. "It's a wholesome team of four brothers. In a market where few developers have survived, they have